

Politics, economics and business ethics



Political philosophy can be seen as the application of moral philosophy to the practical question of the sort of society we want to live in. Economics also emerged from philosophy, before becoming a scientific study of resource management. Both have dealt with issues such as the distribution of wealth, public and private goods, and the laws that protect rights and freedoms, but more recently, philosophy has been called upon to consider the ethics of decisions in the worlds of commerce and finance. What, for example, are a company's responsibilities to its shareholders, customers and employees? Should institutions like banks be trying to make profits or

providing a service to society? Issues of exploitation have also been brought to centre stage: cheap labour in the developing world brings down prices for the consumer, but is morally dubious, and could cause unemployment at home; companies supplying products such as tobacco and even junk food could be accused of exploiting their customers; and exploitation of natural resources raises a host of questions of environmental ethics.